The future of research

Lubchenco and her colleagues created the SBI as both a mission statement and an argument for why ecological research deserved more funding and attention. Their report was published in 1991 in the journal *Ecology* as “The Sustainable Biosphere Initiative: An Ecological Research Agenda.” It was well received within the scientific community, and has been adapted for use at a global level—first in the International Sustainable Biosphere Initiative that was developed in Mexico in 1991, and then in Agenda 21, an action plan adopted in 1992 at the United Nations Earth Summit in Rio de Janeiro, Brazil.

Since 1991, the SBI and its report have influenced a generation of ecologists, opening up new avenues of funding and collaboration, forming committees, putting on workshops, and creating reports to advance its agenda. The SBI has brought ecology into the public eye, and today ecologists sit on advisory boards, influencing both corporate and government policies.

Despite such improvements, Lubchenco still believes that the changes that have been made have not kept pace with the growing dangers the planet faces. New campaigns such as the ESA’s Earth Stewardship Initiative, created in 2013, build on the work of the SBI. Further novel initiatives that continue to help prioritize conservation action include projects such as Conservation Evidence, conceived by British zoologist William Sutherland.